▶ **FACE-OFF: THAROOR VS CHANDRASEKHAR**

VERBAL BOXING

On the campaign trail, three-time Thiruvananthapuram MP Shashi Tharoor of the Congress and Rajeev Chandrasekhar of the BJP spoke to India Today Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa on key issues. Here, in point-counterpoint, are excerpts of their answers





CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

POLITICS OF PERFORMANCE

Shashi Tharoor: 'Performance' has two meanings. One is what I have done for my constituency in the past 15 years—a 60-page report in Malayalam and English gives details of what I have done. The other meaning is 'acting' or 'theatre performance'. That's what the BJP is all about—performing for the media's cameras, performing before the general public. The BJP-ruled Centre had made three specific promises for Kerala; none has been fulfilled, including the setting up of an AIIMS.

Rajeev Chandrasekhar: Very little has happened in the constituency. Despite people being given repeated mandates to Parliament and the state assembly, there's very little to show for it in Thiruvananthapuram. It is widely acknowledged that in the last 15 years, Tharoor has not performed much. He made promises, including ones he should never have made—like transforming Thiruvananthapuram into Barcelona—using them in the classic Congress practice to win elections and forget about them.

"I.N.D.I.A. alliance partners use the same old strategy of fear-mongering and lies—including about CAA and Manipur—to scare minorities"

ATTACKS ON MINORITIES

Tharoor: There is a deep desire across Kerala to defenestrate the central government. We have a BJP government seeking their votes after the horrors they have done to Muslims across north India and to Christians in the Northeast, particularly in Manipur, where 230 churches were destroyed. The PM hasn't even bothered to go and console the people.

Chandrasekhar: People have planted the poison of misinformation about what happened in Manipur. I have explained in my campaign meetings that it's due to deep-rooted ethnic violence and hostility that predates the Modi government. We are trying to fix a legacy problem, including issues of open borders and illegal migration.

"It is fair to ask, is the BJP talking about Mahatma Gandhi's Ram Rajya or about Godse's Ram Rajya?"

COMMUNAL HARMONY

Tharoor: Social harmony has been destroyed. The way in which Indian Muslims have been treated by the Modi government and BJP workers is nothing short of a betrayal of the sacred compact of Indian independence, the very cause for which Mahatma Gandhi gave his life. He died with 'Hey Ram' on his lips and the BJP talks of Ram Rajya. It is fair to ask, is it talking about Gandhiji's Ram Rajya or about Godse's Ram Rajya?

Chandrasekhar: I.N.D.I.A. alliance partners use the same strategy of fear-mongering and peddling lies—including about CAA and Manipur—to scare minorities. I have crisscrossed this constituency and met people